

FORKED TONGUES
An Adivasi Chhatra Sangh protest in Ranchi over the Bhojpuri-Magahi issue

SOMNATH SEN

JHARKHAND

Language Logjam

By Amitabh Srivastava

On February 18, the Hemant Soren-led government in Jharkhand issued a formal notification revoking the decision to include Bhojpuri and Magahi in the regional languages list for Bokaro and Dhanbad districts. A controversy had erupted on December 23 last year after the state government issued a notification to include the two dialects—usually identified with neighbouring Bihar more than with Jharkhand—as regional languages in the two districts. The decision set off an agitation, with members of the state's Adivasi (tribal) and Moolvasi (original inhabitants) communities protesting.

On the face of it, the protests are to do with employment opportunities as Jharkhand has made knowledge of a 'recognised local language' mandatory for Class III and IV category government jobs in the districts. However, if the Soren government expects to douse the controversy with the rollback, it may not be so easy. This is because Bhojpuri is still a recognised language in Palamu and Garhwa districts whereas Magahi has the same status in four other districts of Jharkhand. So, the possibility of similar protests fanning to other parts of the state cannot be ruled out.

With Jharkhand's current unemployment rate hovering at 11.3 per cent, the issue is a touchy one when it comes to district-level jobs of critical significance to local youth. But more than jobs, the language divide has also become a question of identity politics, pitting pro- and anti-Bihar forces against each other in Jharkhand. This is also why protesters have started demanding that land records from the year 1932 be made the cut-off date for anyone to be identified as an original resident of Jharkhand. There are also demands to invalidate the previous Raghubar Das government's 'relaxed domicile policy' that included criteria such as employment for the past 30 years and 1985 as the cut-off year to be identified as an original resident of the state.

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Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar is among those who oppose the move to drop the two languages. He has questioned the exclusion of the two languages and reminded everyone that Bihar and Jharkhand share a common culture and languages. Nitish has not taken any names, nor criticised his Jharkhand counterpart directly, but the reaction of other political forces may not be as measured. While Nitish leads an NDA government in alliance with the BJP in Bihar, the saffron party is the main opposition in Jharkhand where Soren's Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM) leads a government in alliance with the Congress and Rashtriya Janata Dal.

Nitish's argument of a common culture does have some merit. Hived off from Bihar in November 2000, many in the parent state still see Jharkhand as their own. Of the state's 24 districts, as many as 10 share borders with Bihar, which validates the logic of a shared common culture, languages and relations. In fact, the influence of other states in Jharkhand is a given, considering that barring one district (Lohardaga), the other 23 share borders with other states.

So, while a section of Jharkhand politicians insist on promoting an 'exclusive' culture in the name of safeguarding cultural identity, geography plays spoiler in the argument. But then, opposing Bihar is a core theme of many Jharkhand-based parties, including JMM. This is perhaps also why there have been few protests against the inclusion of languages like Bangla, Odiya and even Urdu as regional languages in many districts. Given Jharkhand's current emotionally-charged situation, one has yet to hear the final word on the war of the languages. ■